

Moses Mountain & North Maggie

June 25th to 26th, 2011

Also Featuring: Ron Campbell, Chuck Ernst, Amin Faraday, Mat Kelliher, Bill Payne, Judith Rigney, Diana Bryant, Tova Corman, Stephanie Gylden, Lisa Miyake, Anne Kircher, Alison & Eric Allipport

Full Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157627063724184/>

I've been a Sierra Club leader for a couple of years now and led a fair number of trips. Of all the trips I've either led or been a part of this weekend somehow became the bloodiest.

Considering this was supposed to be an easy WTC student friendly trip that's really saying something.

Ron Campbell and I started out Saturday morning with a total of 14 healthy and (to all appearances) reasonably functional human beings marching down the trail towards peaks and adventure.

Two days later...



(Everyone is pointing to their major injury not to be confused with mere minor scrapes, bruises, and contusions. They include a crushed hand and a nearly sheared off pinky that both required official incident reports. And Tova was just declared a fatality due to sheer amount of blood loss and deep bruising.)

This was a western Sierra trip which on the plus side means a lot more trees and vegetation but also a much longer drive Friday night. It was also a repeat of something I'd tried to do the year before only to be forced to cancel last minute due to the road still being closed due to snow. This year I'd pushed the trip back several weeks but still we had a close call as the road only opened that Friday morning.

The trip started out for me with a bang (of sorts) when I was driving to the airport in Boise at 4 am only to have the back door of my rental car fly open and spill my computer bag and suitcase out in the middle of Vista Boulevard. Oops.

Several plane flights later I was back in California and picked up my first of three carpool persons at 2:15 pm. We arrive at the trailhead at Mountain Home sometime around 10 pm after picking our way through the giant traffic infested cesspit that is LA.

We took one turn through the campground at Shake Camp we decided to bivy at the nearby trailhead. Fortunately there was a conveniently located large dirt parking area with a horse coral at one end. I was in bed an hour or two later though I vaguely remember cars arriving throughout the night with the last apparently getting there at 4 am.

Day 1: Packing In And An Attempt on Moses

Once the sun was up I rolled out of my bag and got moving.

I wandered off through the campground and said hello to Bill, Mat, Chuck, Tova, Judith, and Diana who had all grabbed campsites. Before long we had our entire hoard of 14 people.



One couple was late to arrive but it turned out they were sleeping in one of the vehicles after having arrived around 4 am. That's bad even by my standards.

After a quick and dirty trailhead talk we left a bit later than intended.



I'd been warned by the ranger when I got the permit that we'd likely be the first group down that particular trail and so to expect a lot of downed trees. Sure enough we weren't disappointed.



We'd been told we could make it at least as far as Redwood Crossing but there was no telling if we could make it across the Tule which was flowing extremely high due to the warm weather we'd been having combined with the high snow year. (Noticing a theme from the trips this year?)

We arrived and it became readily apparent why it was called Redwood Crossing.



Ok then. Big log, bit of a drop underneath, just don't fall. Slightly slick also (though the trunk had been attacked with an axe in a few places to add some traction.)

Several members of my party were less than enthused about crossing said log so we spent some time scouting the rocks to either side. I found a few options but nothing better than the log itself.



For an extra bit of safety I crossed the log and set up a hand line running from one side to the other. This seemed to make people feel a bit more comfortable.



I also offered to carry packs for anyone who didn't feel comfortable crossing and several people took me up on the offer. I proceeded to throw a pack over each shoulder and sprint up and down the log at an enthusiastic pace.

And here we encountered the first in a series of mishaps. One pair of participants had a bear proof food bag attached loosely to the outside of their pack. 2/3 of the way across the log this managed to become unattached and plummeted down into the rushing current below.

After a search downstream we determined that a) it was gone and b) it contained two peoples food for the trip. Doh.

We decided we could share food among the group and continued on.



While there had been a few minor obstacles before now there was major vegetation down on the trail and occasional patches of melting snow.



After multiple detours off the trail ranging from easy sidesteps to major reroutes around debris and snow bridges we came across a compact and only slightly soggy site bordering a rather pretty meadow. There were enough tent sites and large rocks for our use and we decided this would be home.







We set up tents, had a quick lunch, and then it was time to leave for Moses.

The big challenge was that we needed to get back across the Tule. There was a crossing on the map but it was predictably obliterated by high water. I tried to wade at one point only to be repeatedly almost knocked over by the swift knee deep current.

We continued north along the bank and eventually came across an overreaching tree and Bill Payne asked for permission to try crossing. I rather like Bill but decided for the good of the group to allow him to attempt to drown himself.

He made it across without too much difficulty by hanging on for dear life to a partially downed tree.



In an attempt to make things as safe as possible for the participants Bill and I waded out into the middle of the current on the downstream side of the branch and did our best to brace the downed tree in place. We then had everyone cross upstream of the branch and use it to pull themselves along.

This was a big sacrifice as the water was **COLD**. If I ever have children I'm pretty sure they'll come out blue now.



One at a time people waded across. Even with the tree the current was strong enough we needed all the traction we could get. Except for one or two people with water shoes most of us just took off our sock and waded across in our boots.

Granted that meant we arrived at the far side rather wet. Full leather mountaineering boots don't give up water that easy.



Once across and only a bit soggy below the knees it was time to climb.

Progress was slow...



And slightly brushy...

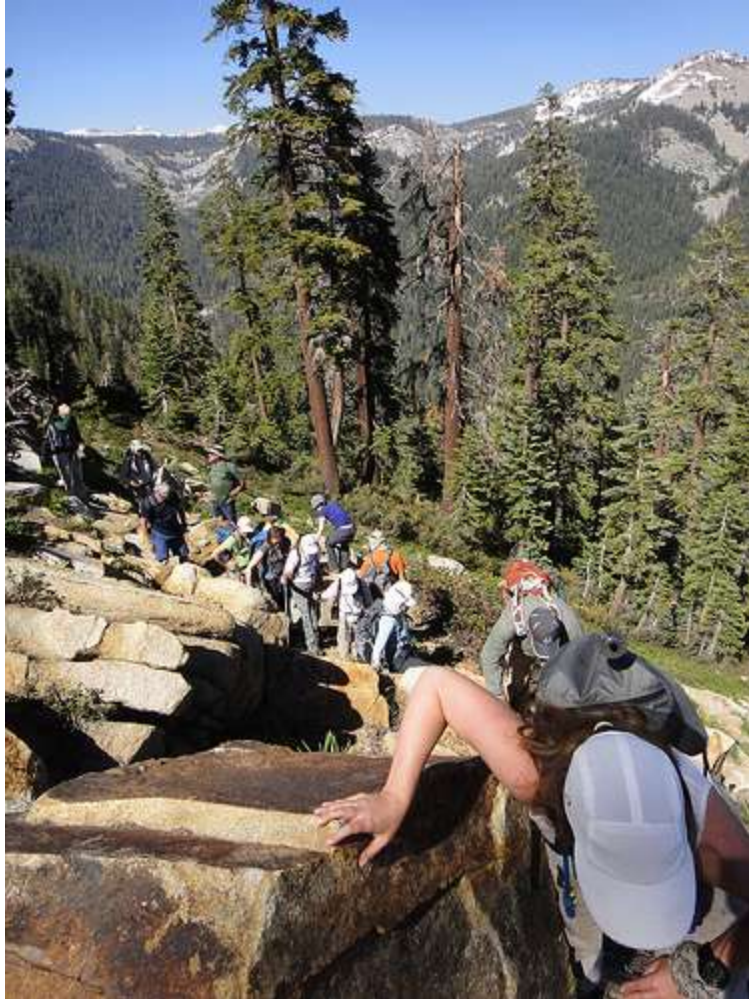


After a fun but of bushwhacking we made it past the vegetation to the rocks.



But finally we started to get some decent views of the area.





We had a few people struggling and with the large group our progress slowed to a crawl. We also had several people take tumbles including one that resulted in a torn pinkie ligament and another that resulted a rather painful twisted knee.



I could now see Moses but it was 5 pm and we at least a few hours and a stream crossing to get back to camp.

I made the reluctant call to turn back and despite this being his second turnaround on Moses Ron agreed.



Slightly disheartened we descended.



We did have one high point during the descent when we saw a bear as we approached a meadow near the stream. (The small black thing in the center of the picture)



We reached the stream crossing and being near dark and lacking zip off pant legs I decided pride played second fiddle to being warm and stripped down to my underwear and waded back into the water to brace the downed tree. Everyone was quite amused.





Once back on the right side of the stream we picked our way through the heavy downed brush and eventually arrived back in camp.



This involved a few more short wadding sections and by the time we made it back to camp I think everyone's boots were squishing.



Some were slightly happier than others.



Back in our meadow wet boots came off and warm stuff went on. We were fortunate in that there were still no mosquitoes.



Dinner of course meant the traditional Sierra Club Happy Hour. With 14 people we had quite the variety. Chocolate covered berries, amaretto brownies of awesome, pudding, and even a few non dessert items...

Eventually we'd eaten all we could manage and rolled ourselves back to our tents and fell asleep to the sound of the river.

Day 2: Maggie & Out

Despite at least one person hoping for further animal encounters no bears disturbed us that night. (Or they came and went without waking anyone.)

The next morning we were up with the sun and had a somewhat relaxed start.

Anne had brought a breakfast experiment so we tried to cook Nutella and banana crapes over my beer keg alcohol stove. It was a noble attempt with some complication due to half frozen Nutella and the fact the crapes kept burning.



I was knocking around in my ever so warm camp snuggie and let Anne try it on for a bit.



High fashion I tell you.

Ron was still having a bit of an issue with his knee after a stumble the previous day and so elected to stay in camp. Fortunately Bill Payne had a rating and so was able to fill in as my sweep.



Having already been north along the stream I elected to start climbing up the slope directly to the north of our meadow.

We managed to find a small amount of brush after a few hundred feet of climbing...



I swung us around to the north along a faint (brush covered) animal trail and eventually we exited the worse of the brush and entered a prominent canyon.



We passed around the north of bump 10,113 and found a surprising amount of snow still on the ground.







But spirits were high...





I was scouting ahead when I heard some rather serious noises from behind. One participant had stepped on a rock which shifted trapping their leg. It hadn't broken anything but it took

two people to remove the rock and no sooner was it off but it shifted and crushed another person's hand.

The hand was swelling but nothing appeared immediately out of place. We elected to continue despite this and several other bloody scrape ups as people tripped left and right.



The final bit was an easy snow slope up.



And then we were there. People kicked back...

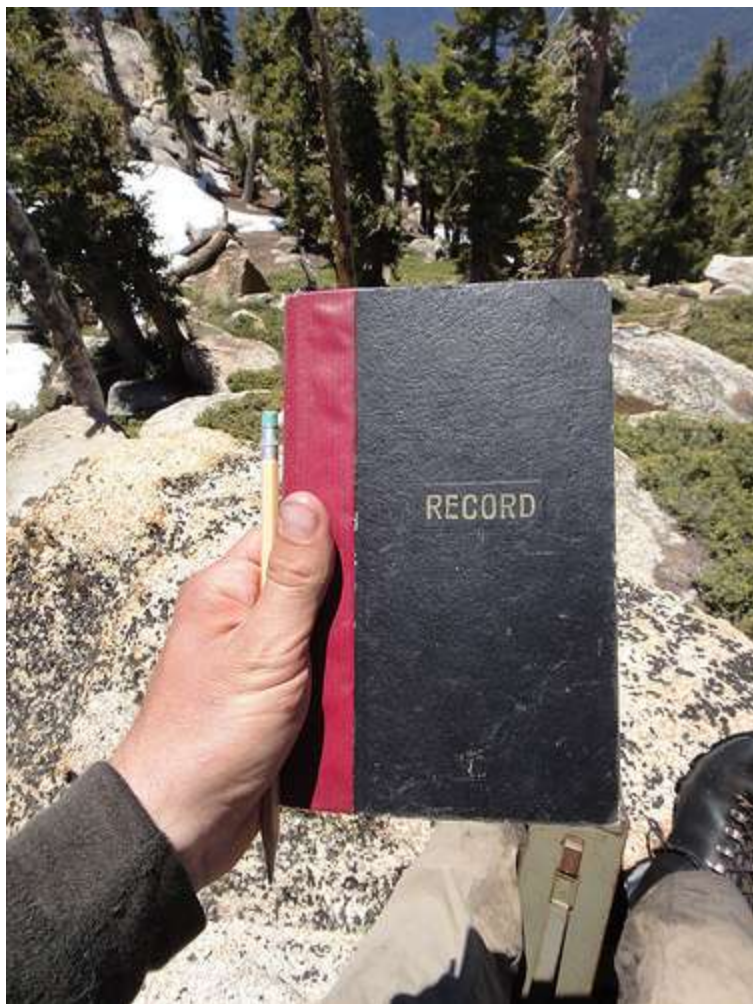


Posed for pictures...





And signed in

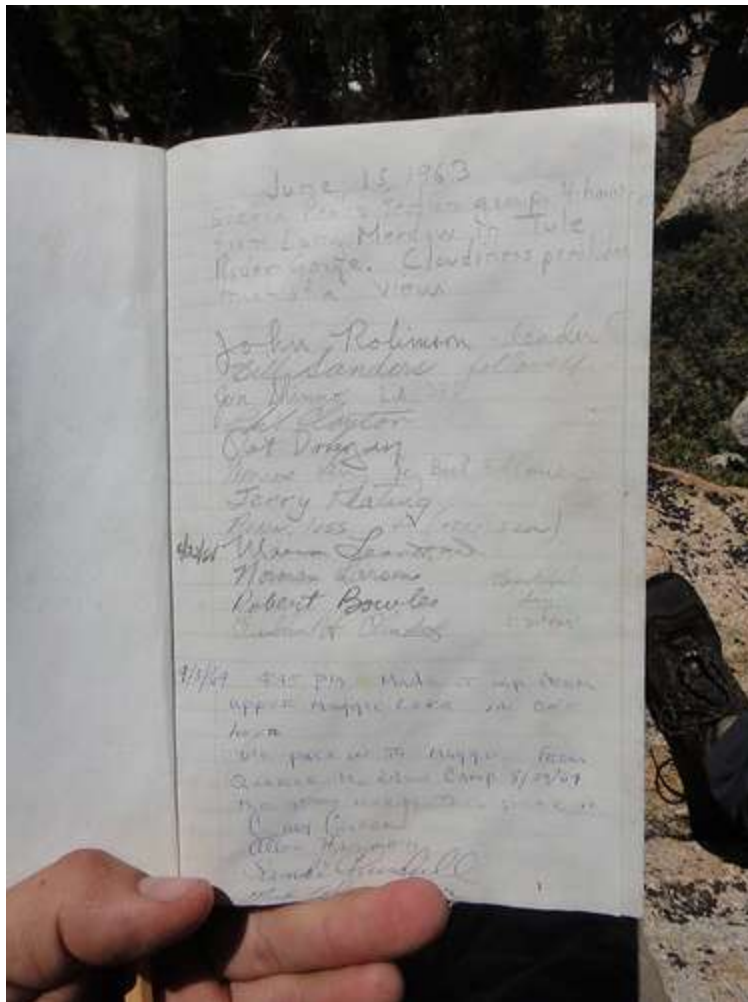


This register belongs to
North Maggie. Please leave
it here forever for future
climbers to enjoy.
Write moderately and
fill every page - make the
register last! Extra not needed
~~Don't write in pencil~~
Thank you

NORTH MAGGIE
MTN.
(10,235')

REGISTER PLACED BY
PEAKS SECTION, SIERRA CLUB

JUNE 15, 1963



1963, not bad!

The descent was rather straightforward outside of even more blood being spilled due to simple stumbles and postholing.



While descending we reached a point at which we were about a half a mile above camp. Unfortunately that half mile appeared to be filled with a sea of 8-10 feet high brush. We could traverse around but what fun would that be...

I dropped us straight down keeping track of my group by the line of swaying brush up behind me. This became the longest period of time the entire trip where someone didn't manage to hurt themselves. Hurray for bushwhacking!

Only slightly worse for the wear we reached camp and found a well rested Ron waiting for us. His knee was still stiff but he'd slept in for several more hours after we left and was all set for the hike out.

We packed up and got moving...



We already knew what to expect and so were unfazed by the downed trees and snow bridges on the way back.



We made it back to the trailhead and tallied up the injuries. Out of 14 people two of us had escaped without visible injury and we had two incident reports to file with Sierra Club. Ouch.

We piled into the cars and headed for home.

Of course things couldn't just end that easy. My carpool stopped in Redondo Beach sometime around 1 am to drop off Lisa and after turning it off for only a few minutes we found my Rav4 wouldn't start.

After trying a few times we decided to try and jump it hoping it was just the battery. Lisa disappeared into the house and returned with a somewhat sleepy Greg in tow who brought his vehicle over.



It took a few attempts but then we had the vehicle running. We also had only a bit under a quarter of a tank of gas left and I wasn't about to risk stopping the engine again to fill up.

We dropped Ron off without incident and proceeded on to Newport Beach. After a hurried transfer of all Anne's gear I drove home and arrived in my garage running on fumes.

40 minutes and one taxi later I was at the Orange County airport with a TSA agent explaining to me that while it wasn't against the rules to bring an iPad through security they were going to rescan my bag just in case mine was packed with explosives. The joys of Monday.